

After the heat, the crisis

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, welcoming you to the last week before EU officials and diplomats return to work en masse ... and wishing a happy rentrée to the handful of working parties and committees already restarting.

In today's Playbook:

- What happens if tourists give up on Europe's sweltering south?
- Coalition of the Willing leaders head for Ukraine to mark Independence Day.
- Faces in the crowd: Boris Dilliès, Roberta Metsola, Nikolina Brnjac, Kristen Michal, Daniel Attard, Sven Simon, Jared Kushner, Franziska Katharina Brantner, Gabriele Visentin, a gray cockatiel and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook podcast: Zoya and Nick discuss Ukraine's desperate need for more missile interceptors ahead of the Coalition of the Willing meeting.

DRIVING THE DAY

COSTA DEL CATASTROPHE: The freak heat waves and raging wildfires that are becoming a regular feature of European summers could create an economic crisis for those parts of the continent that depend on tourism, lawmakers warn.

Sun, sea and spending: After a summer of catastrophic blazes in Spain, Italy, France, Belgium, Croatia and Greece, MEPs told Playbook the EU must act to support Southern European regions that rely on visitors splashing cash.

Need to diversify: "We should all be concerned," said Socialist lawmaker Daniel Attard, a leading member of the European Parliament's Tourism Task Force and an MEP from top travel destination Malta. The EU should focus on the transition towards "new sectors, skills and quality jobs" so that tourism-dependent regions aren't left exposed to increasingly frequent extreme weather, he said.

Worrying trends: Scientists warn wildfires could torch 39 percent more of Europe's landscape in even the best-case scenario, while the EU's Joint Research Center warns that climate change will result in fewer tourists going to the sunny south .

October is the new August: Croatian center-right MEP and former Tourism Minister Nikolina Brnjac predicts heat waves will mean "less tourism during the traditional peak summer season" and that destinations "will have to plan for a different distribution of tourism offer throughout the year, concentrating on late spring and early autumn." Brnjac also said EU wildfire prevention and firefighting responses are becoming more important and should be enshrined in the European Sustainable Tourism Strategy, due to land later this year.

There's a precedent for EU involvement: A handful of countries asked the Commission to compensate operators for lost tourism due to Russia's war in Ukraine. But Brothers of Italy MEP Carlo Fidanza warns the bloc is unreliable when it comes to relief funds, with money pledged by the Commission to help the hospitality sector survive the Covid-19 downturn still not allocated. It's "a nonsense to create illusions" that support will be available, Fidanza says.

Three-pronged approach: A Commission spokesperson said the upcoming tourism strategy "will address sustainability issues in the broadest sense: economic, environmental and social." But don't underestimate the sector's resilience: "So far, tourism has been resisting well across Europe. Destinations and businesses are preparing more, better and earlier." Plus, many Southern European destinations are well equipped to deal with heat waves, the spokesperson said.

It's not just the weather posing a threat. London School of Economics Professor Dimitri Vayanos says overcrowding is the main challenge, with destinations "unable to manage ever-rising tourism flows, causing the quality of their product to deteriorate." Travelers may also need to look for new holiday destinations due to local resentment driven by the cost of living, poor infrastructure and water shortages exacerbated by climate change.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

BIG AND BREAKING

DRY ME A RIVER: The Danube's plummeting water levels are affecting marine traffic and nuclear power plants, and Europe isn't sure what to do about it , Jakob Weizman and Elena Giordano report.

NERD RAGE: Number-crunchers at the EU's powerful markets regulator are fuming at their bosses, according to a new in-house survey obtained by Bjarke Smith-Meyer and Hannah Brenton.

OVAL OFFICE EXODUS: Top Trump administration officials are quitting the White House ahead of hotly contested midterm elections in November, injecting uncertainty at an already tenuous time, my Washington colleagues explain .

IRAN VOWS TO FIGHT ECONOMIC MEASURES: Tehran has warned that "not a single drop of oil will be exported" from either the Strait of Hormuz or the Persian Gulf if the U.S. carries out threats to unleash an "economic D-Day" on Iran.

U.K.'S POST-BREXIT TWIN PREDICAMENT: A woman was left stranded in a foreign airport after Britain's Brexit settlement scheme mistook her for her identical twin sister and prevented her from boarding her flight home, Jon Stone reports.

HOTSPOT DIPLOMACY

FIGHTING FOR INDEPENDENCE: EU leaders are in Ukraine today for the country's Independence Day, even as Russian strikes continue to claim lives . European Council President António Costa was among the first to confirm he'd attend, with others — including Finnish President Alexander Stubb, Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal and Luxembourgish Prime Minister Luc Frieden — expected as well, officials told POLITICO.

In Ukraine's corner: Andy Burnham trumpeted his attendance by saying the U.K.'s support for Kyiv "will not waver ... We will not back down until there is a just and lasting peace." It will be Burnham's first international trip as PM.

Missing in action? Top Donald Trump administration envoy Steve Witkoff and the president's son-in-law Jared Kushner were reportedly set to attend, but a Ukrainian official has told my colleague Veronika Melkozerova the Americans aren't expected.

Words of warning: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy told journalists that Witkoff and Kushner "want to bring victory to President Trump" by finding a format for negotiations with Russia, but the Kremlin would oppose any end to the war unless Ukraine agreed to withdraw from Donbas, along with "other unworthy decisions."

On Nord Stream: Zelenskyy also said over the weekend that Ukraine played no part in the sabotage of Nord Stream gas pipelines between Russia and Europe, following the arrest of a Ukrainian suspect sought by Germany. Bloomberg reports .

FURTHER NORTH: A delegation from the European Parliament is touching down in Greenland today for talks about its relationship with the EU, after Trump repeatedly demanded to take over the territory from Denmark.

What Greenlanders want: Constitutional affairs committee Chair Sven Simon told Max Grier that "Greenlanders themselves must be at the center of decisions about Greenland's future" and that there is scope for "deepening the partnership where there is mutual interest and Greenland wants it."

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you did over the summer break. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

PLAYBOOK OBITUARY

SIIM KALLAS, 1948-2026: Tributes poured in over the weekend after the death of Siim Kallas, a pivotal figure in Estonia's path to joining the EU and the Baltic country's commissioner in Brussels for a decade. Kallas died on Saturday at the age of 77, as confirmed by his daughter , EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs Kaja Kallas.

Historic moment: Siim Kallas oversaw Estonia's transition to a free market democracy after half a century of Soviet occupation, first as president of the Bank of Estonia then as the country's foreign

minister and prime minister. From 2004 to 2014 he took on economic affairs, public administration and transport briefs in the European Commission.

Quiet conviction: European Parliament President Roberta Metsola paid tribute to Kallas , saying it took courage to “build the state and introduce our own currency in the early 1990s” and praising the “quiet conviction he brought with him to Brussels.” Estonia and Europe are “better off because of his life’s work,” Metsola said.

Lasting message: A few days ago, Kaja Kallas delivered a wide-ranging speech written by her father in which he warned democracy is again under threat — this time due to the public losing faith in politicians and democratic institutions. “Democracy is not perfect. Anywhere. Yet the fighting ability of a nation depends on the effectiveness, the credibility of its democracy,” he wrote, according to a text published by Estonia’s public broadcaster .

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

AfD EYES VICTORY: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz needs to beat the far right ... and a critical vote on Sept. 6 in the battleground state of Saxony-Anhalt will be a key indicator of whether he can, Marc Felix Serrao writes.

WAIT AND BAIT: Universities in the U.K. are facing high costs and delays in getting visas for skilled scientists as a result of Brexit, according to a leading neurobiologist working on tiny fish to better understand multiple sclerosis.

WAR OF ATTRITION: Ukraine is reassessing its top targets to inflict economic pain on Moscow, as Russia’s invasion stretches into its fifth year, write Jamie Dettmer and Daria Zakharova.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, high of 23C.

BACK IN THE BUBBLE: Playbook is set to mark the rentrée in style, with the inaugural Brussels Playbook Live event on Sept. 22. Gerardo, Nick and I will be on stage to take you behind the morning briefing, unpack the power plays and policy fights driving the agenda, and sit down with the insiders behind them.

TAAL ORDER: Brussels Minister-President Boris Dilliès is spending the week brushing up on his Dutch after coming under fire for struggling to reply to questions in the language upon taking the oath of office earlier this year. Dilliès promised he’d take improve his language skills, but surprisingly chose the city of Spa (in francophone Wallonia) for an immersive 60-hour course.

SCOOT WHILE YOU CAN: Rental e-scooters have been handed a stay of execution after the Brussels government announced Friday they could remain on the streets until the end of the year (they had been facing a September deadline). Rental e-bikes will be allowed to continue beyond May 2028 and two companies will be selected to operate 4,800 bicycles each.

GIVE US A WING: Signs have appeared around the EU Quarter asking the owner of a gray cockatiel to get in touch after someone’s feathered friend was found near the Schuman Roundabout earlier this month. Playbook wishes them the nest of luck being reunited.

CANBERRA FAREWELL: EU Ambassador to Australia Gabriele Visentin will be holding his farewell drinks Tuesday before wrapping up work on Aug. 28, our Canberra Playbook colleagues inform us. He'll be replaced by Lawrence Meredith, currently the EU ambassador to New Zealand.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz will spend the coming weeks fighting for the survival of his government , after a weekend marred by setbacks.

Paris: President Emmanuel Macron is starting his week with a flurry of activity — although it's unclear if and when he'll get involved in the presidential campaign.

London: Andy Burnham has authorized defense firm MBDA to share classified information with Ukraine for the building of SCALP long-range missiles.

Washington: New Jersey Governor Mikie Sherrill is helping the Democrats reconnect with working-class voters ahead of the 2028 presidential election.

Canberra: The fallout from a television appearance by One Nation's David Farley continues, with major parties locked in a net overseas migration numbers game .

AGENDA

- Coalition of the Willing meets in Kyiv, Ukraine.
- Press briefing ahead of European Council President António Costa's "Tour des Capitales." 2:30 p.m.
- Committee on Constitutional Affairs delegation to Greenland begins its visit to discuss Greenland's constitutional status, climate governance and Arctic sustainable development.
- Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall addresses the opening ceremony of World Water Week 2026 in Stockholm, Sweden.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Johan Van Overtveldt; former MEPs Aileen McLeod, Franziska Katharina Brantner and Riikka Pakarinen; former European Commissioner and MEP Pavel Telička; European Commission's Cecilia Thorfinn; European Parliament's Eszter Zalan; Rasmussen Global's Fabrice Pothier; Sauli Niinistö, former president of Finland.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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